How Ancient People in Japan Adapted After a Huge Eruption

From: ScienceDaily All Mined: 2026-10-19 3 min read

About 7,300 years ago, a **volcano** called Kikai-Akahoya **erupted** under the sea near Japan. It shook the land, made huge waves and covered the ground with thick **ash**.

At that time, **Jomon** people lived in Japan. They hunted and gathered their food. Scientists used to argue about what happened to them. Did they all disappear, or did some survive?

A new study led by Lund University in Sweden found that both things happened. Many people died, but **survivors** moved, made new friends and found new ways to live.

In southern Kyushu, an island in Japan, fewer people lived there even before the eruption. In northern Kyushu, the number of people kept growing. Some **survivors** moved to the northern coast, where sea life came back quickly and gave them food.

Places far from the **volcano** changed too. Their growth stopped or went backward. The eruption may have changed the weather for a while.

Word Treasure

volcano -- A volcano is an opening in the Earth where hot melted rock, gas and ash can burst out.

erupted -- Erupted means burst out suddenly, like a volcano throwing out lava and ash.

ash -- Volcanic ash is tiny bits of rock and glass that fall like dust after an eruption.

survivors -- Survivors are people who stay alive after something dangerous happens.

Jomon -- The Jomon were people who lived in Japan long ago and got food by hunting and gathering.

Background you need

Japan is a country made of islands, and it has many volcanoes.

Long ago, the Jomon people there hunted animals and gathered plants for food.

Scientists learn about people from long ago by studying the things they left behind.

Break it down

WHO: The Jomon people of ancient Japan and scientists led by Lund University
WHAT: A huge volcano erupted, and people responded in different ways
WHERE: Japan, including the island of Kyushu
WHY: Scientists wanted to know whether people disappeared or survived after the eruption

Why it matters

It shows that people can work together and find new ways to live even after a big disaster.

Test what you remember

1. When did the volcano erupt?

- (A) Last year
- (B) About 7,300 years ago
- (C) About 100 years ago
- (D) About 1 million years ago

2. Where did the volcano erupt?

- (A) On the Moon
- (B) In Sweden
- (C) Under the sea near Japan
- (D) In the desert

3. How did the Jomon people get food?

- (A) They bought it at stores
- (B) They hunted and gathered
- (C) They grew it in greenhouses
- (D) They ordered it online

4. What did the new study find?

- (A) Some people died, but survivors moved and found new ways to live
- (B) Nobody lived in Japan
- (C) The volcano never erupted
- (D) Everyone was fine

5. What happened in northern Kyushu?

- (A) Everyone left
- (B) It became a desert
- (C) It sank into the sea
- (D) The number of people kept growing

6. Why did some survivors move to the northern coast?

- (A) They wanted to see the volcano
- (B) Sea life came back quickly and gave them food
- (C) It was warmer there
- (D) There were no animals

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):